READING PASSAGE 2

*You should spend about 20 minutes on **Questions 14–26**, which are based on Reading Passage 2 below.*

The return of the black-footed ferret

The rise, fall, and rise of one of North America's rarest mammals

A The black-footed ferret (*Mustela nigripes*) is a small carnivorous mammal, similar in length to a domestic cat, and is the only ferret species native to North America. For at least 100,000 years they lived in an area that extended almost uninterrupted from southern Canada to northern Mexico. But numbers fell dramatically throughout the 19th and 20th centuries, to such an extent that the black-footed ferret was declared 'possibly extinct'. Then, almost miraculously, it returned from the dead.

B Within the genus *Mustela*, the ferret belongs to the subgenus *Putorius*, of which there are only three extant species: the European polecat; the Siberian polecat; and the black-footed ferret. The European polecat lives in open forests and meadows, and is thought to be the ancestor of the domestic ferret. The Siberian polecat looks more similar to the black-footed ferret, and leads a similar life on open grasslands and semi-desert regions across Russia, China and Siberia.

C Ferrets probably evolved in Europe between three and four million years ago, and dispersed into North America across an ice-age land bridge at least two million years ago. They then advanced south-eastward to the Great Plains through ice-free passageways. The black-footed ferret's history in North America is inextricably linked to the creature which became almost its sole prey — the prairie dog. These small rodents are a type of ground squirrel which live in networks of underground tunnels, known as burrows. The black-footed ferret's short legs and long, slim body make it superbly adapted for life in the burrow systems of its prey.

D Spending virtually all their time underground, black-footed ferrets have always been elusive. Ferrets are never mentioned in accounts of the early explorers or pioneers who crossed the Great Plains by wagon train during the early to mid-1800s. They were, however, occasionally listed in records kept by fur companies in the upper Missouri River basin during that period. Black-footed ferrets were not officially recognized by scientists until 1851, when a description and drawing of one featured in a book by the renowned naturalist John James Audubon and Reverend John Bachman. For over two decades, no other specimens were seen, and scientists even began to question their existence. Then, in 1874, a Dr Elliott Coues issued a request for specimens through the popular magazine *The American Sportsman*, and was soon rewarded. With these he was able to add to Audubon's description, and confirm the existence of the black-footed ferret.

E In the decades that followed, European settlement across North America changed the landscape dramatically, with vast areas being transformed into crop and grazing land. As agriculture and ranching expanded, the black-footed ferret's main prey, the prairie dog, became a target for extermination, and was eventually eradicated from 98% of its original range. The result was devastating for black-footed ferret populations throughout the continent. Even today, the prairie dog is still trapped and poisoned, because ranchers believe that it competes with livestock for grass — a notion that belies recent research showing that prairie dogs and cattle feed on different plants.

F As late as the 1950s, black-footed ferrets were still thought to occur in low densities throughout most of their historic range. However, by the 1960s, the only known population was a small colony in south-western South Dakota. In 1967, the US Fish and Wildlife Service classified the black-footed ferret as an endangered species, and in 1974 the South Dakota colony disappeared. Finally, in January 1979, the last ferret in a captive-breeding programme died — making the black-footed ferret the first mammal to be declared extinct in the Northern Hemisphere in the 20th century.

G But that was not the end of the story. In 1981, a farm dog called Shep carried an odd-looking creature to its owner's ranch house in Meeteetse, Wyoming. The rancher put the carcass in his fridge and alerted state officials. The dog had found a black-footed ferret — which led to efforts again being made to save the species. An intensive search in the region led to the discovery of a 130-strong population. This wild colony thrived for a while, but disaster struck again and the number of animals was drastically reduced by the disease distemper — probably contracted from domestic dogs. In 1985, in a final bid to save the species, the remaining 18 individuals in the colony were trapped for a new captive-breeding programme. This project was successful, and there are now more than 2,000 black-footed ferrets in captivity across the US and Canada.

H A reintroduction programme began in 1991. Before they can be reintroduced into their natural habitat, captive ferrets have to learn to hunt and escape from predators. They are first held in pens on the prairie, where they are fed prairie dog meat. Once the ferrets associate these animals with food, keepers unleash live prey into the pens, and they soon realise that they must hunt or go hungry. Then, to get the ferrets used to living underground, they have to be tempted into the holes with food.

I Reintroduction programmes are now underway across central USA, but there is one location that is key. The Janos area on the US-Mexico border is the obvious place to reactivate the continent's wild black-footed ferret population, being one of the most important remaining grassland ecosystems in the Americas, and home to an abundance of prairie dogs. At the last report, the future of the black-footed ferret finally looks promising.

Questions 14–16

Complete the sentences below.

Choose ***NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS*** *from the passage for each answer.*

Write your answers in boxes 14–16 on your answer sheet.

14 The black-footed ferret shares most characteristics with its relative, the ______.

15 North American ferrets are thought to have originally come from ______.

16 The ______ is the black-footed ferret's primary source of food.

Questions 17–22

Look at the following events (Questions 17–22) and the list of dates below.

Match each event with the correct date, ***A–H****.*

Write the correct letter, ***A–H****, in boxes 17–22 on your answer sheet.*

17 An appeal for evidence of black-footed ferrets was published.

18 A scheme for releasing captive-born black-footed ferrets into the wild was launched.

19 The black-footed ferret first appeared in a scientific work.

20 The discovery of a single black-footed ferret led to renewed hope for the species.

21 North America's last wild-born black-footed ferrets were taken into captivity.

22 Efforts to save the black-footed ferret were officially announced as having failed.

List of Dates

A 1851
B 1874
C 1967
D 1974
E 1979
F 1981
G 1985
H 1991

Questions 23–26

*Reading Passage 2 has nine paragraphs, **A–I**.*

Which paragraph contains the following information?

*Write the correct letter, **A–I**, in boxes 23–26 on your answer sheet.*

23 reasons for the sharp decrease in black-footed ferret populations

24 the procedure by which black-footed ferrets are taught to survive in the wild

25 mention of doubts about whether there was such an animal as a black-footed ferret

26 reference to a site which is ideal for the release of black-footed ferrets into the wild

Questions 14–16 句子填空

题号	答案	题干翻译	定位句	定位句翻译	详细解释
14	**Siberian polecat**	黑足鼬与它的亲缘动物 ______ 共享最多特征。	B段：**The Siberian polecat looks more similar to the black-footed ferret, and leads a similar life on open grasslands and semi-desert regions...**	西伯利亚艾鼬看起来与黑足鼬更相似，并且在开阔草原和半沙漠地区过着类似的生活。	题干中的 **shares most characteristics with its relative** 对应原文的 **looks more similar** 和 **leads a similar life**。B段提到欧洲艾鼬和西伯利亚艾鼬，但真正与黑足鼬最相似的是 **Siberian polecat**。
15	**Europe**	北美黑足鼬被认为最初来自 ______。	C段：**Ferrets probably evolved in Europe between three and four million years ago, and dispersed into North America...**	鼬类可能在三四百万年前起源于欧洲，后来扩散到北美。	题干中的 **originally come from** 对应原文的 **evolved in Europe**。注意这里问的是"北美的ferrets最初来自哪里"，答案是地点 **Europe**。
16	**prairie dog**	______ 是黑足鼬的主要食物来源。	C段：**...the creature which became almost its sole prey — the prairie dog.**	这种动物几乎成了黑足鼬唯一的猎物——草原犬鼠。	题干中的 **primary source of food** 对应原文的 **almost its sole prey**。所以答案是 **prairie dog**。

Questions 17–22 日期匹配题

题号	答案	对应日期	题干翻译	定位句	定位句翻译	详细解释
17	**B**	**1874**	一则寻求黑足鼬证据的呼吁被发表。	D段：**Then, in 1874, a Dr Elliott Coues issued a request for specimens through the popular magazine The American Sportsman...**	随后，在1874年，Elliott Coues博士通过流行杂志《美国运动员》发出征集标本的请求。	题干中的 **an appeal for evidence** 对应原文的 **issued a request for specimens**。因为标本可以作为这种动物存在的证据，所以答案是1874，对应 **B**。
18	**H**	**1991**	将人工繁殖的黑足鼬释放回野外的计划启动了。	H段：**A reintroduction programme began in 1991.**	一项重新引入计划于1991年开始。	题干中的 **a scheme for releasing captive-born... into the wild** 对应原文的 **reintroduction programme**。reintroduction指"重新引入自然栖息地"，所以答案是1991，对应 **H**。
19	**A**	**1851**	黑足鼬首次出现在一部科学作品中。	D段：**Black-footed ferrets were not officially recognized by scientists until 1851, when a description and drawing of one featured in a book...**	直到1851年，黑足鼬才被科学家正式认可，当时一本书中出现了对它的描述和图画。	题干中的 **first appeared in a scientific work** 对应原文的 **a description and drawing... featured in a book**。虽然原文没有直接说"scientific work"，但由 **officially recognized by scientists** 和自然学家 Audubon 的书可以判断。答案是1851，对应 **A**。
20	**F**	**1981**	一只黑足鼬的发现重新给该物种带来了希望。	G段：**In 1981, a farm dog called Shep carried an odd-looking creature... The dog had found a black-footed ferret — which led to efforts again being made to save the species.**	1981年，一只名叫Shep的农场犬叼回了一只奇怪的动物……这只狗发现的是黑足鼬，这使得人们再次努力拯救该物种。	题干中的 **discovery of a single black-footed ferret** 对应原文中狗发现一只黑足鼬；**renewed hope** 对应 **efforts again being made to save the species**。答案是1981，对应 **F**。
21	**G**	**1985**	北美最后一批野生出生的黑足鼬被带入圈养环境。	G段：**In 1985, in a final bid to save the species, the remaining 18 individuals in the colony were trapped for a new captive-breeding programme.**	1985年，为了最后一次拯救该物种，这个群体中剩下的18只个体被捕捉，用于新的圈养繁殖项目。	题干中的 **last wild-born black-footed ferrets were taken into captivity** 对应原文的 **remaining 18 individuals... were trapped for a new captive-breeding programme**。答案是1985，对应 **G**。
22	**E**	**1979**	拯救黑足鼬的努力被官方宣布失败。	F段：**Finally, in January 1979, the last ferret in a captive-breeding programme died — making the black-footed ferret the first mammal to be declared extinct...**	最后，在1979年1月，圈养繁殖项目中的最后一只黑足鼬死亡，使黑足鼬成为北半球20世纪第一个被宣布灭绝的哺乳动物。	题干中的 **efforts to save... were officially announced as having failed** 对应原文的 **declared extinct**。这说明当时官方认为拯救失败了。答案是1979，对应 **E**。

Questions 23–26 段落信息匹配题

题号	答案	题干翻译	定位句	定位句翻译	详细解释
23	**E**	黑足鼬数量急剧下降的原因。	E段：**European settlement... changed the landscape dramatically... transformed into crop and grazing land. As agriculture and ranching expanded, the black-footed ferret's main prey, the prairie dog, became a target for extermination...**	欧洲人在北美定居改变了景观，大面积土地被改造成农田和牧场。随着农业和畜牧业扩张，黑足鼬的主要猎物草原犬鼠成为被消灭的目标。	这一段解释了黑足鼬下降的两个核心原因：一是栖息地被农业和牧场改造；二是主要猎物 prairie dog 被大规模消灭。因此对应 **reasons for the sharp decrease**。
24	**H**	黑足鼬被训练在野外生存的过程。	H段：**Before they can be reintroduced... captive ferrets have to learn to hunt and escape from predators... they are fed prairie dog meat... keepers unleash live prey... they have to be tempted into the holes with food.**	在被重新放归自然前，圈养黑足鼬必须学会捕猎和躲避捕食者……它们先被喂草原犬鼠肉，随后饲养员释放活猎物，最后用食物引导它们进入洞穴。	题干中的 **procedure** 对应这一段的训练步骤：先认识食物，再捕猎活物，再适应地下洞穴生活。因此答案是 **H**。
25	**D**	提到人们怀疑是否真的存在黑足鼬这种动物。	D段：**For over two decades, no other specimens were seen, and scientists even began to question their existence.**	二十多年里，没有其他标本被发现，科学家甚至开始怀疑它们是否存在。	题干中的 **doubts about whether there was such an animal** 对应原文的 **began to question their existence**。所以答案是 **D**。
26	**I**	提到一个非常适合将黑足鼬释放回野外的地点。	I段：**The Janos area on the US-Mexico border is the obvious place to reactivate the continent's wild black-footed ferret population...**	美墨边境的Janos地区显然是恢复北美大陆野生黑足鼬种群的理想地点。	题干中的 **a site which is ideal for the release** 对应原文的 **the obvious place to reactivate... wild black-footed ferret population**。后文还解释原因：这里是重要草原生态系统，并且有大量草原犬鼠。因此答案是 **I**。